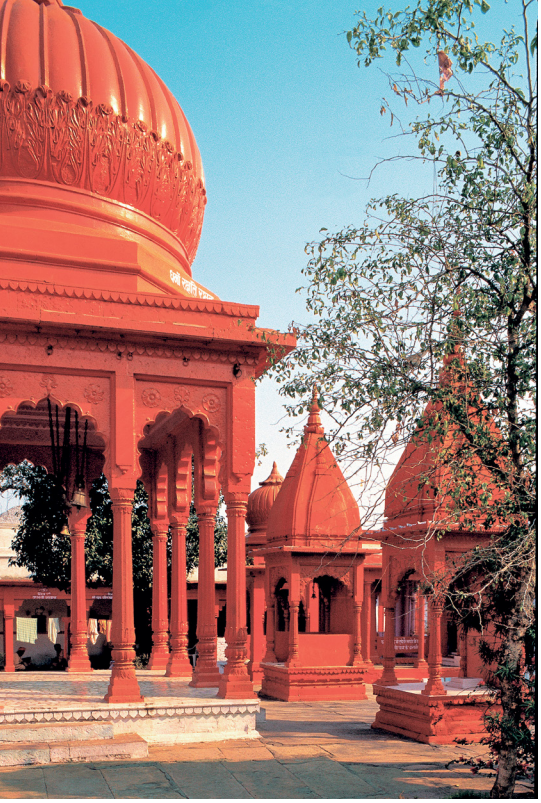






BOOKS

WHERE THE GODS DWELL

Having completed 75 years, *Marg* has released a special issue on temples that's a feast for the senses

Founded by writer Mulk Raj Anand in 1946, *Marg* has tried achieving its aim of "developing a socially active and culturally engaging language of art" with admirable courage. At a time when niche-interest magazines are going out of vogue and print, *Marg* is evidently not in the game only to survive. To celebrate its 75th year, the art magazine has released *Readings on the Temple*, a sumptuous "bumper issue" that collects many articles it has previously published on temples in India and beyond.

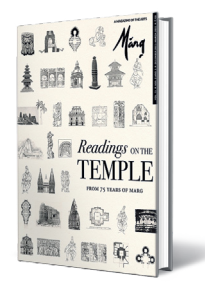
A temple is hardly ever without meaning. As Khajuraho somewhat predictably proves, even its walls are significant. Though essential to a temple's fabric, devotion oftentimes has a tendency to blanket detail with fervour. By assigning scholars the task of deconstructing the complex symbology, architecture and art of Hindu places of worship, *Marg* has helped us understand better the nuances of heritage. Like pilgrims, every contributor here approaches the temple with different intent. While *Readings...* makes obvious the frequency with which the theme of temples has recurred in *Marg*, this 310-page volume signals towards an abundance of interpretation religion can, at times, preclude.

In 'Visualising the Gods', an essay about the importance of *darshan*, Gilles Tarabout writes how a painting of Narasimha—an embellishment on the outer wall of a Kerala temple—came to be worshipped by locals. "Offerings and rituals are never without effect," writes Tarabout, "and Narasimha, so it is said, really began to reside in his image [...] a proper consecration had to be organised in order to ritually contain the divine power." Similarly, most of *Marg*'s writers seem to look at faith as a result of the human condition, not a riddle that needs solving.

In no way, however, does this innate respect for religiosity discount curiosity. Scholarship invariably starts with inquiry, and those who have contributed to *Marg* down the years all seem to have begun with a question: Were post-Kushan builders in Uttar Pradesh aware of the techniques their Roman and Byzantine counterparts were employing? Why is cave 16 at Ellora, the Kailasa Temple, not counted among the twelve *jyotirlingas*? Given Hinduism's emphasis on *dharma*, how does one explain the explicit eroticism that has been portrayed in temple sculpture? In each case, the answers that *Marg*'s scholars arrive at feels unexpected. Even pieces that are decades-old somehow seem novel.

In his introduction, *Marg*'s editor, Naman P. Ahuja, writes, "Temples have once again been prominently in the news. The growth of Hindu nationalism [...] has brought temple studies into focus: Why does this form of building matter so much?" While politics barely features in *Readings...*, it's sometimes hard not to look at its writing and images as political. Catherine B. Asher, for instance, notes that Sawai Jai Singh had ensured the exterior of the Govinda Deva temple he had built in Jaipur resembles Shah Jahan's public halls. And, then, there's the picture of the Gyanvapi mosque on page 241—a reminder that in India, the doors of masjids and mandirs are often adjacent and identical. ■

– Shreevatsa Nevatia



READINGS ON THE TEMPLE FROM 75 YEARS OF MARG
by Naman P. Ahuja (editor)
THE MARG FOUNDATION
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